

Chapter 28-1

Liang Shi had thought about encountering Zhou Yi'an before coming here.

When she didn't see Zhou Yi'an at the auction, she thought Zhou Yi'an wouldn't come.

Anyway, the Liang family's invitation was definitely delivered to the Zhou family, though she didn't know whether it was handed to Father Zhou or to Zhou Yi'an.

Now, the Liang family's desire to curry favor with the Zhou family was known to everyone.

To be precise, the Zhou family had now become the hot commodity that everyone in their circle was eager to please.

Although they still couldn't compare to the legendary "Twin Heroes" families—the Shen family and the Gu family—with Father Zhou's recent promotion, they had instantly become the object of flattery for all the major wealthy families.

No matter when, one must always follow the policy winds.

And Father Zhou was now the sky¹ of Haizou City, so naturally, Zhou Yi'an also rose with the tide, being addressed with smiling "Miss Zhou" wherever she went.

Being praised by so many people, Zhou Yi'an naturally developed the illusion that she could get whatever she wanted.

And she became increasingly unrestrained.

Actually, this circle was quite corrupt.

Whether officials or businesspeople, most of their second-generation offspring were good-for-nothings.

So just in case, each family had many children.

If this one doesn't work out, there's always another.

Zhou Yi'an's arrival was also within Liang Shi's expectations.

But even though she had anticipated it, suddenly hearing such a voice by her ear still made her want to hit someone.

She didn't know if it was Liang Shi's imagination, but she always felt that Zhou Yi'an was flirting with her, and in a particularly cheap way.

Just like the male classmates in elementary school who, because they had a crush on a girl, would pull her braids or steal her snacks.

The methods were very—low.

Liang Shi's gaze slowly turned to her. Zhou Yi'an's outfit was still the same as usual: a black and white tuxedo, shoulder-length hair hanging over her shoulders, not wearing any earrings.

When Zhou Yi'an met her gaze, she raised the wine glass in her hand and took a light sip. The transparent rim was stained with lipstick, and a trace of wine remained at the corner of her mouth. She raised her hand and gently wiped it away, the wiping motion done unhurriedly, as if she was seducing someone.

Zhou Yi'an wasn't bad-looking.

But she wasn't Liang Shi's type.

Moreover, Liang Shi had felt uncomfortable from the first time she saw her.

So now, faced with her deliberate actions, she only felt disgusted.

"Baby." Zhou Yi'an swirled the wine glass in her hand, deliberately lowering her voice while leaning forward, moving closer to Liang Shi, saying with a half-smile, "You're so beautiful today that I can't take my eyes off you."

Liang Shi: "....."

Her voice was cold: "Then gouge out your own eyes."

"Hiss." Zhou Yi'an covered her chest. "Baby, you have such a cruel heart."

"Get lost." Liang Shi frowned. "Stop calling me such disgusting terms of endearment."

"Then what should I call you?" Zhou Yi'an reached out wanting to hook her chin, but Liang Shi avoided it and slapped her hand away with a crisp sound.

The recoil made Liang Shi's palm numb.

Zhou Yi'an's hand immediately turned red.

Zhou Yi'an looked down at her hand, first stunned, then smiled after a moment. "Baby, do you know that the more you hate me, the more I like you?"

She stuck out her tongue tip and lightly licked her lower lip, her voice taking on a seductive tone. "I really want to take you back to my bed....."

Liang Shi lifted her foot and stepped on Zhou Yi'an's shoe.

Today's high heels had thin heels, and stepping on them was particularly sharp, causing Zhou Yi'an to gasp in pain, her flirtatious words interrupted.

Liang Shi sneered coldly, "Then you'd better like me a lot more."

She looked at Zhou Yi'an with disdain. "Because I will hate you very much."

Zhou Yi'an's body curled up somewhat from the pain. "Baby, lift your foot."

Liang Shi's heel twisted on her instep, then stepped back, saying lightly, "Do you know what you look like right now?"

Zhou Yi'an took a heavy breath and was angered into laughter. "I'm fucking—"

"You're like a dog in heat anytime, anywhere." Liang Shi said viciously, "Disgusting."

Zhou Yi'an's expression changed, her aura instantly turning cold as she looked at Liang Shi, suddenly curling her lips. "You're just taking advantage of the fact that I like you to bully me."

Liang Shi: "....."

"You're also taking advantage of the fact that this is a society ruled by law, constantly challenging my bottom line." Liang Shi sneered.

Zhou Yi'an glanced at the person beside Liang Shi. "Is this the Omega you like? She does look quite good."

Xu Qingzhu's gaze was cool as she met Zhou Yi'an's appraising look, not avoiding it at all.

She had already guessed Zhou Yi'an's identity when she came over.

But she hadn't said anything.

First, she felt this was Liang Shi's own business and that Liang Shi could definitely handle it; second, she was somewhat curious to watch the show, wanting to see what Liang Shi would do.

After all, Zhou Yi'an hadn't shown her hand yet, and no one knew what she wanted to do.

Today seemed like just a simple banquet, but the identities of the various guests were not simple.

Perhaps deals worth tens of millions or even hundreds of millions would be struck during the toasting and socializing.

Making trouble at such a banquet was not a wise choice.

If she disrupted Father Liang's business, the Liang family would definitely face another storm after the banquet ended.

Taking the initiative to step forward when Zhou Yi'an was talking with Liang Shi would definitely intensify the tension between them.

She could only watch from the sidelines.

But now that Zhou Yi'an had turned her gaze to her, she naturally wouldn't sit and wait for death.

After a long standoff, Zhou Yi'an smiled and said, "Baby, your little Omega wife is quite interesting."

Liang Shi frowned slightly. "That's none of your business."

Xu Qingzhu then gracefully linked arms with Liang Shi and suddenly smiled. "Baby, who is this? Won't you introduce us?"

Her voice was cool and clear. Perhaps due to her speaking habits, when she called someone "baby," her tone always rose at the end, carrying a hint of coquettish reproach.

Their skirts immediately pressed together.

Since they were wearing evening gowns, there was no barrier on their arms—it was direct skin-to-skin contact.

Footnotes:

¹ "Sky" - In Chinese culture, referring to someone as "the sky" means they hold the highest authority or power in a particular domain, essentially meaning they are the supreme ruler or most influential person.

Author's Note: [If any author's notes were present in the original text, they would be translated here]

Chapter 28-2

The autumn nights in Haizou City carried a hint of coolness. Long hair hanging down could only block the neck from the wind's invasion.

But her arms were still cold.

An Omega's body was naturally more delicate than an Alpha's, and her skin felt several degrees colder.

The moment Xu Qingzhu's arm pressed against hers, Liang Shi noticed she shivered slightly, but her face showed no sign of it, still maintaining a smile that was even better than a female celebrity's expression management on the red carpet.

Liang Shi's heart tightened when she called her that, and she coughed awkwardly.

"Baby." Xu Qingzhu turned to face her, whispering coquettishly in her ear: "You're letting people call you baby again. Don't come back to the room tonight—go sleep on the sofa."

She deliberately lowered her voice, but controlled the volume just enough for Zhou Yi'an to hear.

Zhou Yi'an's expression immediately changed. "I f—"

Before she could finish her curse, Xu Qingzhu coldly interrupted her, showing none of her previous gentle demeanor. "This lady, your behavior is detrimental to our family harmony. Please conduct yourself with dignity."

Zhou Yi'an: ".....?"

"Baby." Zhou Yi'an was angered into laughter, looking at Liang Shi. "Baby, you really aren't afraid of death, are you?"

Liang Shi glanced at her, her tone indifferent. "My wife is right. Please conduct yourself with dignity."

She deliberately emphasized the words "conduct yourself with dignity."

Zhou Yi'an felt anger burning in her chest.

Xu Qingzhu then stood on her tiptoes, moving close to Liang Shi's ear, but ears were the most sensitive part of Liang Shi's body.

She couldn't stand someone suddenly getting so close, so she instinctively moved away, but Xu Qingzhu reached out and pulled her head back. Caught off guard, Xu Qingzhu's lips touched her ear.

It was even that Xu Qingzhu had planned to whisper in her ear, and just as she opened her mouth, Liang Shi's ear came closer.

She instinctively pursed her lips, just happening to capture Liang Shi's ear.

Ears were always the most susceptible to cold.

Under the autumn evening breeze, Liang Shi's ear was ice cold.

Hot lips gently pressed against the cold ear, transmitting warmth to it.

Both Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi froze for a moment.

Xu Qingzhu's heart pounded nervously. Despite the bustling banquet with many people raising glasses and chatting—it wasn't quiet at all.

But she could accurately capture the sound of a rapidly beating heart amidst all the noise and commotion.

She didn't know if it was hers or Liang Shi's.

Nervously, she instinctively licked her lips, but after extending her tongue tip and touching Liang Shi's skin, she quickly withdrew it.

Liang Shi felt moisture on her ear.

It was a soft, even hotter tongue tip than her lips, but it had just peeked out and then fearfully retreated.

Like a mimosa¹.

Liang Shi's entire body tensed up nervously, and Xu Qingzhu's hand holding her arm tightened in that instant, gently pinching the skin on the inside of her arm.

Her fingertips carried a trace of coolness.

Liang Shi let out a soft breath, and Xu Qingzhu immediately retreated.

The moment became somewhat awkward.

Xu Qingzhu had originally intended to put on a show for Zhou Yi'an, but ended up being too clever for her own good, trapping herself in an embarrassing situation.

Zhou Yi'an looked at the two of them, feeling inexplicable anger rise in her heart, and sneered: "What are you doing? In broad daylight and in front of everyone."

Zhou Yi'an's gaze swept over Liang Shi's ear. "Baby, you just said I was like a dog in heat, so what about your little Omega wife? In front of so many people, you're already about to start doting on her? Is there something you can't do at home? Or do you just like having people watch you two—do it together?"

She deliberately emphasized the word "do" heavily, adding an indescribable innuendo.

"If you really think that way, why not just take off your evening gowns? I can help you two..." Zhou Yi'an's words became increasingly vulgar. "Live stream it."

Hearing this, Liang Shi frowned and pulled Xu Qingzhu closer to her, even putting her arm around Xu Qingzhu's waist.

But it was a gentleman's hold.

She just lightly rested it on her waist, with her entire forearm suspended in air. It was quite a test of arm strength, but Liang Shi had often done this before and was already used to it, not feeling tired at all.

Xu Qingzhu's evening gown had a fitted waist, just right for her to embrace.

"Sorry." Liang Shi said: "We are a legally married couple with a marriage certificate. My wife just wanted to whisper something to me, unlike you who goes into heat anytime, anywhere toward a married Alpha. I suppose in the eyes of lewd people, everything appears lewd."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

She directly crushed the wine glass in her hand.

Crimson wine mixed with transparent glass fell to the ground, the liquid snaking across the gray floor like blood.

This commotion caused everyone present to look over.

Liang Shi held Xu Qingzhu and stepped back, conveying only one message—she's the one going crazy, it has nothing to do with us.

Liang Xinhe approached at just the right time. He had drunk quite a bit for socializing, and since alcohol made his face flush, his complexion was now reddish. "Liang Shi, what are you doing?"

"Nothing." Liang Shi replied: "Zhu Zi² and I were just chatting."

"You chat away." Liang Xinhe said: "Sister-in-law is coming with me."

Liang Shi was puzzled: "Huh?"

"I'm taking sister-in-law to meet some people." Liang Xinhe said: "They're all in jewelry-related businesses."

Liang Shi understood—this was about expanding Xu Qingzhu's network. Naturally, she had no intention of objecting.

Only then did Liang Xinhe notice the broken wine glass on the ground and Zhou Yi'an standing there with cold, angry eyes. He immediately inquired in his capacity as host: "Miss Zhou, did something happen to you? If there's anything we can help with, please don't hesitate to ask."

Zhou Yi'an gave him a sidelong glance, her arrogant attitude fully displayed.

She didn't even bother with surface politeness.

Liang Xinhe hit a soft nail³, but was only embarrassed for a few seconds before calling to the waiters: "Quickly clean up the things on the ground, be careful not to hurt the guests."

The waiters repeatedly acknowledged.

When Liang Xinhe was about to leave with Xu Qingzhu, Liang Shi naturally wanted to follow.

But Liang Xinhe looked back at her with disgust: "What are you following for?"

Liang Shi: ".....?"

"Second brother, you're taking my wife away." Liang Shi said: "Of course I have to follow."

She didn't want to stay here alone with Zhou Yi'an.

Liang Xinhe waved his hand: "Go, go, go. I'm just taking your wife to meet a few people, I'll return her to you in a bit. You following along would just be a burden."

Liang Shi: "....."

She said weakly: "At least I'm also a member of the Liang family. I should support my wife's reputation."

Liang Xinhe suddenly paused and called her name seriously: "Liang Shi."

Liang Shi: "Yes?"

Liang Xinhe said very objectively, trying not to bring any emotion into it: "Have you really forgotten what kind of mess you used to be?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She coughed lightly: "Second brother, I've changed."

Liang Xinhe waved his hand: "Alright, I'll return your wife to you in a moment. Among the people we're meeting, there are some you've offended before. If they see you, they'll probably turn around and leave. I advise you to stay put."

After saying this, he glanced at Zhou Yi'an who was standing there like a statue, and lowered his voice: "Mom said you and Zhou Yi'an were high school classmates with a pretty good relationship. You can have a good chat with her. Our family's south city land still depends on the Zhou family."

Liang Shi: ".....?"

She couldn't tell for a moment whether what Liang Xinhe said was true or false.

But Liang Xinhe's eyes were too pure.

He looked like he was simply believing what Qiu Zimin had told him, so he didn't know that his Alpha sister was being harassed by another person of hidden gender who was 99% likely to be an Alpha.

After Liang Xinhe finished speaking, he was about to leave with Xu Qingzhu, but Xu Qingzhu lifted her skirt and said softly: "Second brother, wait a moment."

"What's the matter?" Liang Xinhe asked.

Xu Qingzhu turned around and beckoned to Liang Shi.

Liang Shi walked over unhappily: "What's wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "Lower your head."

Liang Shi instinctively covered her own ears. That kind of stimulation just now was very nice, but she really couldn't handle it again.

She... really wasn't that much of a gentleman either.

Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly and whispered coquettishly: "Come here."

In others' eyes, it looked like a young couple flirting playfully.

Liang Shi also obediently bent down and lowered her head, while Xu Qingzhu raised her hand, her fingers gently brushing over Liang Shi's earlobe.

Where her fingertips passed brought a tingling, tickling sensation that extended from the tailbone all the way to the top of her head, making her nervous yet comfortable, involuntarily letting out a satisfied sigh.

This time Xu Qingzhu really lowered her voice, speaking in a volume only the two of them could hear: "Be careful of Zhou Yi'an."

Liang Shi nodded: "I know."

Footnotes:

¹ Mimosa - Also known as the "sensitive plant," this plant folds its leaves when touched, used here as a metaphor for someone who is shy and quickly retreats when approached.

² Zhu Zi - A cute nickname for Xu Qingzhu, literally meaning "little bamboo."

³ Hit a soft nail - A Chinese idiom meaning to be politely but firmly rejected or rebuffed.

Author's Note: [If any author's notes were present in the original text, they would be translated here]

Chapter 28-3

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After Xu Qingzhu and Liang Xinhe left, Liang Shi stood by the pool in a daze.

There was no one in the pool.

Everyone was wearing evening gowns, holding wine glasses, wandering among the crowd, busy networking and toasting with each other.

This was nothing more than a social gathering.

Liang Shi holding a wine glass was just a decoration.

She had barely touched the wine in her glass.

Usually, she only liked to drink a little when she was alone, as it helped her sleep.

Normally, she didn't drink alcohol.

She also didn't bother with Zhou Yi'an.

Probably finding the teasing boring, Zhou Yi'an followed a man and left, turning to join the main theme of this banquet.

Holding a wine glass, smiling as she met one person after another.

Liang Shi had no interest in such things.

She just searched among the crowd with her eyes for the person she wanted to see, but never found her.

Cheng Ran hadn't come.

She did see Cheng Ran's brother, who walked away in disgust when he saw her.

She thought she could have peace and quiet until Xu Qingzhu returned, but before long, Zhou Yi'an appeared behind her, even taking off her tuxedo and trying to drape it over Liang Shi's shoulders.

Fortunately, Liang Shi was always alert. She turned around and gave Zhou Yi'an a sidelong glance, avoiding her touch.

"What are you doing here again?" Liang Shi said.

"Baby, you're being too heartless." Zhou Yi'an looked at her. "People have self-respect. You can't hurt my heart again and again."

"I hope you actually have some self-respect." Liang Shi said. "Stop pestering me. I have a wife."

Zhou Yi'an raised her hand to her forehead. "Your little Omega wife? That stick of bamboo?"

Liang Shi: ".....Her name is Xu Qingzhu¹."

"I don't care what bamboo she is." Zhou Yi'an curled her lips in a light smile. "Is she prettier than me? Does she treat you better than I do? Baby, you should know, I can make you..."

She moved closer, lowering her voice like a devil's whisper: "I can make you lose your wife anytime."

Liang Shi: "....."

This fucking crazy bitch.

How on earth did the original owner get involved with this kind of crazy bitch?

This was truly speechless—speechlessness opening the door for speechlessness, reaching the ultimate level of speechlessness.

"Could you please look in a mirror?" Liang Shi said. "From top to bottom, from face to figure, which part of you compares to Xu Qingzhu?"

"So you're not choosing me because I'm not as pretty as her?" Zhou Yi'an smiled. "Then would it be okay if I scarred her face?"

Liang Shi: ".....Why don't you just kill me instead?"

Zhou Yi'an's expression froze. She wanted to smile but couldn't, making her expression particularly eerie. Her lips curved up then twitched several times as she asked incredulously: "Baby, you're actually willing to die for her?"

Liang Shi: "....."

It wasn't a question of whether she was willing to die for Xu Qingzhu.

Of course she wouldn't, at least not currently.

But who would want to be pestered by this kind of crazy bitch?

It was just an angry remark.

Anyway, given her current situation, if Xu Qingzhu died, she wouldn't survive either.

In a sense, she really would have to die for Xu Qingzhu.

"What about you? Would you die for me?" Liang Shi asked her.

Zhou Yi'an fell silent.

"I really want that Omega to disappear. Baby, I can't stand her being intimate with you. What should I do? I want to have you." Zhou Yi'an said. "If you were with me, I would definitely treat you very well."

"Could you please stop being crazy?" Liang Shi said. "I don't like you, I even hate you."

"It doesn't matter." Zhou Yi'an moved closer to her, her tone ambiguous and sultry. "Love will grow over time."

Liang Shi: "....."

She glanced around the venue. Some people had already noticed them.

After all, one was the usually dissolute Third Miss Liang, and the other was the newly prominent Miss Zhou.

What were these two doing together?

Had the Liang family secured that piece of land in the south?

When Liang Shi's gaze swept over them, everyone promptly looked away.

"Baby, why don't you consider it?" Zhou Yi'an said. "After all, you're the first woman I've ever wanted to have in my life."

Liang Shi pursed her lips. "Are you going crazy?"

Zhou Yi'an: "How could liking you be going crazy?"

Liang Shi sneered coldly. "Then how about we go crazy together today?"

Zhou Yi'an became interested. "Oh?"

"If you lose, you're never allowed to trouble Xu Qingzhu again." Liang Shi negotiated terms with her.

Zhou Yi'an clicked her tongue. "Baby, you really protect her tightly."

She kept calling her "baby" with every sentence, making Liang Shi want to slap her.

The last man who had sexually harassed her like this had already been sent to the police station.

Liang Shi had climbed up from the bottom, so she naturally understood that when dealing with people more powerful than herself, she couldn't confront them head-on.

Dealing with different people naturally required different methods.

Liang Shi looked at her provocatively. "Do you dare to bet?"

Zhou Yi'an nodded with interest. "Sure."

Liang Shi suddenly pressed closer to her. "You know I can't swim, right?"

Zhou Yi'an's expression changed slightly, her pupils contracting. "What are you going to do?"

Liang Shi grabbed her hand and sneered coldly. "Zhou Yi'an."

"Hm? Liang Shi, what are you doing?" Zhou Yi'an's tone was tense.

Liang Shi placed Zhou Yi'an's hand on her own shoulder and smiled at her. "You want to compete in craziness?"

As soon as she finished speaking, before Zhou Yi'an could react, Liang Shi immediately shouted loudly: "No~!"

Then she stumbled backward, falling straight into the water with a splash.

Zhou Yi'an's hand was still suspended in mid-air, making it look like she had pushed Liang Shi down.

Liang Shi thrashed in the water, splashing violently, and desperately shouted: "Help... help me!"

Then her head completely submerged underwater.

The splashing water immediately caught the attention of those around them. Everyone was stunned for a moment.

Some people wanted to go down and rescue her, but because Zhou Yi'an was standing there, completely frozen, no one dared to go down for the moment.

The person Miss Zhou had pushed down must have offended Miss Zhou.

If they rashly went down to rescue her, wouldn't they also offend Miss Zhou along with her?

No one was willing to take such a risk.

So everyone looked at each other in confusion. Someone asked: "Who was pushed down?"

"I don't know."

"It seemed like Third Miss Liang was standing there just now?"

"Holy shit!"

"....."

To bully Third Miss Liang on the Liang family's territory—even if Third Miss Liang was worthless, they couldn't let Zhou Yi'an bully her like this.

Moreover, Third Miss Liang couldn't swim.

She only thrashed twice before sinking into the water.

After a few seconds, Zhou Yi'an finally came to her senses and smiled bitterly.

Even knowing this was a trap Liang Shi had set for her, she still couldn't help but want to go down and save her.

As she had said, she couldn't swim.

So she was betting with her life.

This round, Zhou Yi'an had lost.

She had never realized before that Liang Shi could be this crazy—so crazy that she didn't even care about her own life.

Just as she was about to leap into the water, a green figure flashed by like the wind.

Splash.

The light blue skirt floated on the water surface due to buoyancy, like blooming blue fireworks.

Soon, light blue and water green became entangled together.

Footnotes:

¹ Xu Qingzhu - The name literally means "Xu Clear Bamboo," which is why Zhou Yi'an dismissively calls her "that stick of bamboo."

Author's Note: [If any author's notes were present in the original text, they would be translated here]

Chapter 28-4

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When Liang Shi was rescued, she first spat out two mouthfuls of water, her whole body weak and powerless.

She leaned weakly against Xu Qingzhu's shoulder, while Xu Qingzhu wiped the water from her face and laid her flat.

With such a big incident happening, almost all the Liang family members came out.

Except for Qiu Zimin, who was playing mahjong in the room.

Liang Xinhe looked at the weakly collapsed Liang Shi, crouched down to pat her face, and anxiously called: "Liang Shi, Liang Shi."

"Second brother, please step aside." Xu Qingzhu said: "I'll perform CPR on her."

She clasped her hands together and began pressing on Liang Shi's chest.

Press after press, Liang Shi kept spitting out water.

She was completely soaked, her long hair lying wet on the ground. As an Alpha, she looked particularly disheveled.

After she had vomited up all the water accumulated in her abdomen, she planned to slowly regain consciousness.

The original owner couldn't swim, but Liang Shi could.

She would never gamble with her life against others.

This time was just to scare Zhou Yi'an.

She had seen Liang Xinhe and Xu Qingzhu coming out of the banquet hall, so she timed her jump perfectly.

Because Liang Xinhe had been a swimming champion in high school and almost made it to the provincial team.

But she hadn't expected that the person who jumped in to save her would be Xu Qingzhu.

For an Omega whose body hadn't fully recovered to drag an Alpha who was taller and larger than her out of the water, even with the help of water's buoyancy.

It was still an exhausting task.

And Xu Qingzhu was anxiously performing CPR on her, which somewhat disrupted Liang Shi's plan.

So she vomited out more of the water she had deliberately swallowed earlier, shortening the time to save Xu Qingzhu some effort.

Just as she was about to open her eyes, Xu Qingzhu had already pinched her nose and began performing mouth-to-mouth resuscitation.

"....."

An Omega's lips were very soft, having just come out of the water, carrying a wet coolness.

She gave her a large breath of air.

Liang Shi's hand hanging to one side suddenly clenched the hem of her skirt.

Xu Qingzhu single-mindedly performed mouth-to-mouth resuscitation, her lips falling and leaving again and again.

On the third time, Liang Shi coughed a few times as Xu Qingzhu pulled away, then slowly opened her eyes.

Even though her composure was disrupted by Xu Qingzhu's actions and she felt somewhat flustered, she could still force herself to finish this performance.

After opening her eyes, she looked around, and when she saw Zhou Yi'an, fear flashed in her eyes, then she shook her head: "Don't... don't kill me."

Everyone: ".....?"

Well, this was quite a revelation.

Before Liang Shi fell into the water, everyone thought it was just a dispute between the two, so Zhou Yi'an pushed Liang Shi into the water.

But Liang Shi's first words upon waking were looking at Zhou Yi'an and saying, "Don't kill me"?

What kind of grudge was this?

"Who wants to kill you?" Liang Xinhe asked coldly: "Don't be afraid."

Liang Shi shook her head: "Can't... can't say..."

She began coughing, holding onto Xu Qingzhu's hand, coughing continuously until she almost coughed up her lungs. When she raised her head again, her face was flushed, several strands of hair still disheveled, but she didn't look ugly—rather, she had a tragic beauty.

She said in a hoarse voice, weak: "If I tell... our family won't be able to... participate in the south city land bid."

She spoke intermittently, but could make every person present hear clearly.

An actor's vocal training was being displayed to its fullest at this moment.

Having been polished in front of cameras for many years, Liang Shi already knew which of her expressions were beautiful, what actions could evoke people's empathy.

She did neither more nor less, showing Liang Xinhe a weak smile: "Second brother, I'm... cough cough... I'm fine."

Liang Xinhe was already furious, looking at Zhou Yi'an.

The crowd watching the drama were very moral, clearing out the space around Zhou Yi'an.

Liang Xinhe roared: "Zhou Yi'an, you're truly lawless! No matter how much power you have, this is a society ruled by law—murder requires paying with one's life! Do you really think the Liang family is a soft persimmon¹ for you to squeeze at will? If my sister had died here today, I would definitely make you pay with your life!"

"She..." Zhou Yi'an looked at Liang Shi, who flashed her a victorious smile, but only for an instant before immediately returning to her weak and pitiful state.

Zhou Yi'an swallowed back the words she was originally going to say: "She fell in herself, believe it or not."

No one would believe it.

Liang Shi had calculated well.

Everyone saw her reach out and push Liang Shi.

No one would believe that Third Miss Liang, who couldn't swim, would bet her life against someone.

Liang Shi was quite crazy too.

Zhou Yi'an sneered coldly and answered Liang Xinhe: "Isn't she still alive?"

"If she had died, you would be dead now too." Liang Xinhe said.

Zhou Yi'an: "Oh."

"Second brother, don't... don't blame Miss Zhou." Liang Shi said: "Miss Zhou kept pressing me about where Cheng... Cheng Ran is. I don't know, so she got angry and acted."

Everyone: "....."

So there was another layer to this?

"It's my fault for being useless." Liang Shi's voice was still intermittent, sounding very labored, but she could accurately deliver every word to the ears of everyone present: "I couldn't help Miss Zhou..."

Someone in the crowd said: "This is too domineering, wanting to kill someone over a small disagreement."

Zhou Yi'an's expression changed slightly.

When someone led the narrative, others quickly followed suit.

"Exactly, the Zhou family doesn't have this kind of family culture. I've met the eldest Miss Zhou before—a very gentle and virtuous young lady."

"The Zhou family wasn't in Haizou City in previous years. They just moved back not long ago. Mr. Zhou has been lax in discipline, usually too indulgent with this youngest daughter, which has cultivated such a spoiled temperament."

"Third Miss Liang isn't exactly a pushover either, but today she was bullied like this."

"Does Mr. Zhou know his daughter is so arrogant outside? She's ruining all the good reputation he's built up over the years."

"Mr. Zhou is honest and upright, most just and fair, usually decisive and stern, but he just can't handle this youngest daughter."

"But you can't let her continue like this. She's bound to cause trouble eventually."

"Isn't today already causing trouble? Third Miss Liang almost died."

"....."

They seemed to be whispering among themselves, but actually every word they said could be heard by Zhou Yi'an.

Zhou Yi'an had already clenched her fists.

What did these people understand?

How could she bully Liang Shi?

It was clearly Liang Shi who, taking advantage of her affection, kept pressing and bullying her.

But everyone looked at Third Miss Liang with sympathy, all sighing.

She looked like she was down to her last breath, quite pitiful.

Liang Shi had achieved her goal and was ready to faint at any moment.

But she felt that if she fainted now, her Omega wife might want to carry her back.

Helplessly, she could only cough weakly: "So... so cold."

"Quickly." Liang Xinhe ordered: "Go back inside."

A nearby waiter immediately came to help her, and Xu Qingzhu also lent a hand to support Liang Shi.

Liang Shi wanted Xu Qingzhu to leave with her, but Xu Qingzhu only let the waiter accompany her while staying behind herself.

Footnotes:

¹ Soft persimmon - A Chinese idiom meaning someone who is weak and easily bullied or taken advantage of.

Author's Note: [If any author's notes were present in the original text, they would be translated here]

Chapter 28-5

The early autumn wind was strong. Xu Qingzhu's long hair hung wetly on her body, and her water-green dress clung tightly to her.

Liang Xinhe told her to go, saying he would handle things here, but Xu Qingzhu shook her head.

"I'll settle this account for Liang Shi." Liang Xinhe said: "Don't worry, go change your clothes first, be careful not to catch cold."

Xu Qingzhu took a light breath: "Second brother, let me handle this."

Zhou Yi'an was already planning to leave. She had just turned around when Xu Qingzhu called out: "Miss Zhou."

Zhou Yi'an turned back, raising her eyebrows contemptuously: "What? Do you want to condemn me too?"

Xu Qingzhu walked over and raised her hand to deliver a slap.

Zhou Yi'an was completely stunned.

Everyone present was also stunned.

Father Zhou had just arrived. When he heard his daughter had caused trouble, he immediately rushed over, only to see his daughter being slapped.

Father Zhou: "....."

His heart was filled with mixed emotions.

When Zhou Yi'an raised her hand to slap back, she was blocked by Liang Xinhe.

Xu Qingzhu stood in the wind, her slender figure seeming like it could be blown away at any moment, but when she looked at Zhou Yi'an, her gaze was firm and her words rang out forcefully: "This slap was for my wife. She can't swim well, but you knowingly pushed her into the water. If we hadn't arrived in time, what we would have seen would be a corpse. My parents-in-law would have had to bury their child, I would have lost my wife, and the child in my belly would lose her mother before being born. How would you have me raise her?"

Everyone's gaze toward Zhou Yi'an instantly changed.

Put this way, Zhou Yi'an was a criminal!

It would be a pity not to send her to prison for a few years.

But Xu Qingzhu continued: "Mr. Zhou works to establish livelihood for the people¹ and create peace for all generations, but what are you doing as his daughter? You're treating human life carelessly! You're bringing shame to him! You're adding a dark stain to his otherwise upright career. Your reckless behavior shows you don't regard China's criminal law, you despise human life, you despise the law. Even though I'm just an insignificant ordinary citizen, I can see Mr. Zhou's contributions. He works hard for the people, but you're ruining his reputation. I feel sorry for him."

This speech directly elevated the entire incident.

Even Father Zhou, standing behind, couldn't help but feel angry along with her.

He usually kept his tail between his legs², working diligently and conscientiously, only to have his beloved daughter making enemies everywhere?

This was truly unbearable.

Xu Qingzhu finally took a heavy breath: "I believe Miss Zhou definitely won't let our married couple off after today's events, but we won't be afraid either. After all, I believe heaven's justice is clear³, and there is royal law and justice. If one day we two unfortunately meet with harm, Miss Zhou will definitely be the police's first suspect."

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

"Fuck!" Zhou Yi'an was so angry she cursed.

Father Zhou had already left the scene and didn't stand up to speak for Zhou Yi'an.

Everyone understood—Mr. Zhou had given up on Zhou Yi'an.

Just as Liang Xinhe was about to step forward, the silent Liang Xinzhou spoke first: "Although the Liang family is just in business, that doesn't mean anyone can bully us. Even if my sister has done wrong, it's for our family to discipline her. If she breaks the law, naturally the law will punish her. I don't know what kind of vigilante justice Miss Zhou thinks she's dispensing? Is this still the 21st century?"

Zhou Yi'an: "....."

Liang Xinzhou said: "If anything happens to my sister in the future, the first person the Liang family will suspect is definitely Miss Zhou."

"On what grounds?" Zhou Yi'an frowned. "Are you all crazy?!"

"On the grounds that you have precedent." Liang Xinhe and Liang Xinzhou said simultaneously.

After the farce ended, Liang Xinhe lowered his voice and asked: "Sister-in-law, are you pregnant?"

Xu Qingzhu said calmly: "I was lying to her."

To stir up emotions, the elderly and children were often most effective.

Liang Xinhe: "....."

He hadn't expected that his seemingly gentle and weak sister-in-law could kill without a blade⁴.

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When Liang Shi was helped inside by the waiter, Qiu Zimin and the others happened to come out of the room.

The group had been playing mahjong all evening and were now somewhat tired, planning to find a place to rest.

Seeing Liang Shi being helped in, Qiu Zimin's expression immediately changed: "What happened?"

"Nothing..." Liang Shi still maintained her weak image.

The waiter beside her answered: "Third Miss just fell into the water."

Qiu Zimin immediately cleared the way: "Help Miss to rest, and have someone prepare ginger syrup."

The waiter nodded: "Yes."

"Is this A-Shi?" A woman's voice suddenly rang out.

Liang Shi saw Qiu Zimin's shoulders tremble, then she turned around with a fawning smile: "Yes, Mrs. Qi."

The person called Mrs. Qi wore a blue-green qipao⁵ that beautifully outlined her graceful waist curves. She wore a jade bracelet on her arm and walked unhurriedly to Liang Shi's side, raising her hand to touch her face: "It's been so long since we met. You've grown so much."

This arm gave Liang Shi a very strong sense of familiarity.

She frowned and avoided it.

"It's been so long." Mrs. Qi smiled: "Has A-Shi forgotten me?"

Her fingers were painted with crimson nail polish: "That would make me sad."

Liang Shi frowned slightly as a memory suddenly flashed through her mind.

It was this jade bracelet.

It was this hand that pulled her into the dark room, stripped the young her of her clothes, and made her stand facing the wall as punishment.

More precisely, it was the original owner.

The fear remaining in this body awakened at this moment, and she couldn't help but shiver.

Liang Shi remained silent and didn't answer her words.

Mrs. Qi said: "Well, we'll have a good chat next time we have the chance. Go change your clothes."

She glanced over Liang Shi's chest: "Our A-Shi has grown up."

Liang Shi: "....."

Footnotes:

¹ Establish livelihood for the people - A classical Chinese phrase referring to creating conditions for people to make a living and prosper.

² Kept his tail between his legs - Chinese idiom meaning to behave cautiously and humbly, keeping a low profile.

³ Heaven's justice is clear - A traditional Chinese belief that heaven sees all and will ensure justice is served.

⁴ Kill without a blade - Chinese idiom meaning to harm someone through words or psychological means rather than physical violence.

⁵ Qipao - A traditional Chinese dress, also known as cheongsam, characterized by its high collar and form-fitting silhouette.

Author's Note: [If any author's notes were present in the original text, they would be translated here]

Chapter 28-6

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The inexplicable memories that had surfaced earlier left Liang Shi feeling somewhat troubled.

She went back to her room to change into casual clothes, and before long, Xu Qingzhu also walked in.

When Xu Qingzhu first entered, she still looked imposing, but after closing the door, she leaned directly against it, continuously trying to catch her breath.

Liang Shi inquired: "What's wrong?"

Xu Qingzhu: ".....I just did something big."

Liang Shi: "Hm?"

Xu Qingzhu: "I hit Zhou Yi'an."

Liang Shi was shocked: "What?"

"Taking a risk, I suppose." Xu Qingzhu said: "But it was successful. At least it'll have some deterrent effect."

Moreover, this move successfully brought Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe into their camp. The Liang family would also protect them—it wasn't a loss.

Liang Shi suddenly regretted not staying to watch.

After Xu Qingzhu had calmed down for a long while, she finally settled down, but the first thing she asked was: "Were you acting just now?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Yes, she was acting.

But how could she say that?

If she admitted it, wouldn't that make her a pervert who deliberately took advantage of Xu Qingzhu?

Her silence represented her answer.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her and said flatly: "You're quite good at acting."

Liang Shi: ".....I can explain."

Xu Qingzhu: "I don't want to hear it."

Liang Shi: "How about listening anyway?"

Xu Qingzhu: "Then go ahead."

Liang Shi: "....."

She was suddenly at a loss for words.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't mind this matter. She just said: "You don't need to misunderstand. Even if it had been someone else who fell into the water, I would have saved them too."

Liang Shi: "....."

Crack.

Her heart broke a little.

"I know." Liang Shi said: "You're beautiful and kind-hearted. So do you want to change clothes now? There are some in the closet, though they might be a bit big."

The clothes prepared here were all Alpha sizes, so they would be somewhat large for an Omega.

Xu Qingzhu nodded.

She took a T-shirt and casual pants from the closet, turned sideways to wring the water from her hair, and was about to take off her evening gown when she froze—she had almost forgotten there was another person in the room.

Liang Shi was also considerate. She proactively turned around: "Go ahead and change, I won't look."

Xu Qingzhu reached behind to unzip her dress.

Without vision, one's hearing becomes more acute, so Liang Shi could hear Xu Qingzhu unzipping the dress, the gown falling to the ground, then unfolding the T-shirt to find the front and back, and putting it on over her head.

Each step could almost be determined from the sounds alone, making her increasingly restless. Later, she simply covered her ears.

Soon, Xu Qingzhu said: "I'm done changing."

Only then did Liang Shi turn around, but Xu Qingzhu said: "By the way, did you see that woman in the qipao earlier?"

"Mrs. Qi?" Liang Shi asked.

"I'm not sure." Xu Qingzhu said: "When she saw me, she said some very strange things."

"What did she say?"

"She said she never expected A-Shi would marry someone like this, and that I bore some resemblance to Jiaojiao." Xu Qingzhu repeated her words, then asked Liang Shi: "Who is Jiaojiao?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She'd be damned if she knew.

Xu Qingzhu didn't press her about it. Later, servants brought ginger syrup.

Both of them drank it down.

Author's Note: [If any author's notes were present in the original text, they would be translated here]

Chapter 28-7

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Perhaps because of encountering Mrs. Qi, Liang Shi actually had nightmares that night.

In the dream was a dim background, and that enclosed room again. She entered in her own current state and saw the young original owner.

The original owner had been crying, but when she heard the sound and turned around, seeing Liang Shi, she actually smiled foolishly.

That smile was eerie.

It gave Liang Shi goosebumps all over.

The undeveloped little girl wasn't particularly attractive, but her body showed obvious signs of having been abused.

Liang Shi crouched down and asked her: "Did someone hit you?"

She didn't speak, just smiled.

Then the room door opened, and Mrs. Qi with her jade bracelet walked in. She was still wearing that blue-green qipao, and she was pulling along another little girl.

Mrs. Qi called out: "Jiaojiao."

Mrs. Qi made Jiaojiao lie on the bed, then made the little girl stand there and watch.

Mrs. Qi raised her hand and pinched Jiaojiao's body, asking her: "Are you obedient?"

Jiaojiao cried and said: "Obedient... Mommy, please don't hit me anymore..."

Mrs. Qi smiled coldly: "If you're obedient, why did you tell on me to daddy? Daddy doesn't want you anymore."

Jiaojiao could only cry "wuu wuu wuu."

Mrs. Qi looked at the little girl standing on the ground: "Don't look. You were also sent here by your mommy."

Mrs. Qi touched her hair: "I just said our Jiaojiao needed a companion, and she sent you over."

The little girl cowered.

Mrs. Qi said: "Your mommy told me I could discipline¹ you however I wanted."

Then Mrs. Qi walked over, and the little girl backed away step by step, showing a terrified expression.

Mrs. Qi smiled and asked: "Where should I hit first?"

Suddenly, she kicked the little girl in the stomach.

Liang Shi watched in horror and cried out: "No!"

She reached out to stop it, but her body was ethereal, passing through the dim dust.

The lights suddenly turned on.

Liang Shi abruptly opened her eyes and touched her forehead—it was covered in cold sweat.

Just now... was that the original owner's childhood?

Did Qiu Zimin hate the original owner that much?

She was just a child—what kind of deep hatred could there be?

Liang Shi was still shaken when Xu Qingzhu beside her asked: "Did you have a nightmare?"

She nodded: "A little."

They had returned early tonight, and having both fallen into water, they had gone to bed early.

There was still a quilt separating them in the middle.

Xu Qingzhu had slept for a while then woken up, planning to use the bathroom, when she discovered Liang Shi was having nightmares.

That's when she turned on the light to wake Liang Shi up.

Liang Shi covered her violently beating heart as Xu Qingzhu handed her a glass of warm water: "Are you okay?"

Liang Shi nodded: "I'm fine."

It was just that the feeling from earlier was too real—so real it was as if she had experienced it herself.

This way, neither of them could sleep.

Xu Qingzhu sat there and opened her computer while Liang Shi felt bored.

After spacing out for a while, Liang Shi suggested: "Should we watch a movie?"

Xu Qingzhu was wearing glasses and working on a proposal. Hearing this, she glanced at Liang Shi, seeing she was still somewhat frightened, and nodded: "Should we go downstairs?"

"We can watch in the bedroom. I had the butler fix the projector." Liang Shi said as she turned on the projector and got out of bed to rummage through the drawer.

She had also had the butler purchase some DVDs.

On top was a yuri² film—*The Handmaiden*.

Liang Shi glanced at it—the keywords were listed as same-sex and suspense.

When she was still in that other world, people had recommended this movie to her. She had always said she wanted to watch it, but had put it off several times.

Now finding this was quite novel, so she asked Xu Qingzhu: "Is this okay?"

Xu Qingzhu could be called a movie desert³.

She didn't really watch movies, so she left it entirely up to Liang Shi.

Liang Shi put the DVD into the drive, then got back into bed.

Footnotes:

¹ Discipline - The Chinese term used here (調教) has connotations of training or disciplining with potential abusive undertones, which is why it appears particularly sinister in this context.

² Yuri - A genre focusing on romantic relationships between women, equivalent to Girls' Love (GL).

³ Movie desert - Chinese slang meaning someone who rarely watches movies or has very limited knowledge about films.

Author's Note: [If any author's notes were present in the original text, they would be translated here]